WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-07-27 to 2026-08-02

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SUMMARY

This week's COMAP Journal Bot brief traces how political behavior is shaped by digital platforms and institutional design. The strongest new work examines cross-platform QAnon counterpublics, exposure to untrustworthy sources on Facebook and Instagram, protest mobilization, redistricting reform, political polarization, and changing patterns of U.S. immigration enforcement. A second cluster connects AI to governance and everyday decision-making, from competitive pressure on families to adopt general-purpose AI to privacy with AI companions, disparate-impact auditing, legal infrastructure, and safety regulation.

Three threads stand out for the lab:

- Platform environments can strongly reshape exposure and participation without producing simple, immediate persuasion effects.
- Computational and multimodal measurement is moving closer to the social processes of interest, including physiological audience alignment, linguistic polarization, judicial citation communities, and mobility rhythms.
- AI governance research increasingly treats regulation, benchmarking, interpretation, and discrimination as institutional design problems rather than purely technical ones.

This digest was prepared early on Saturday, 2026-08-01, before the nominal window closes on Sunday, 2026-08-02. It reflects records available at collection time; publications appearing later in the window may be recovered in a subsequent catch-up or late-additions section.

HIGHLIGHTS

Networked Counterpublics and Contentious Publicity: A Cross-Platform Analysis of QAnon on Parler and Twitter

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-07-27

Why it matters · Its cross-platform comparison shows how the same technical affordances can support distinct identity-building and agenda-setting practices across Parler and Twitter.

Open article →

Untrustworthy sources on Facebook and Instagram in 2020: Concentrated exposure but no attitudinal effects

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-07-31

Why it matters · A platform-scale field experiment separates concentrated exposure from persuasion, showing that a large reduction in untrustworthy content did not immediately move attitudes or beliefs.

Open article →

Social dynamics of AI adoption in parents' educational decisions

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-07-31

Why it matters · The study identifies a social-pressure ratchet in family AI adoption: peer use raises demand even while evidence about skill risks increases support for collective restrictions.

Open article →

The Bio-Functional Audience: Shared Physiological Alignment to Narrative Media

COMMUNICATION RESEARCH · 2026-07-28

Why it matters · By combining eye tracking, heart rate, and electrodermal activity, the article offers a genuinely multimodal account of how narrative media synchronize audiences over time.

Open article →

Redistricting Reforms Reduce Gerrymandering by Constraining Partisan Actors

AMERICAN POLITICAL SCIENCE REVIEW · 2026-07-30

Why it matters · A sequential-game measure of partisan leeway makes heterogeneous redistricting institutions comparable and links reform constraints to less bias and greater competitiveness.

Open article →

Most people who agree with you won't protest: Predictors of marches and demonstrations from six decades of research

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-07-31

Why it matters · This six-decade meta-analysis isolates robust predictors of protest participation, including organization membership and digital or social media use, while clarifying where evidence remains weak.

Open article →

Life course trajectory segregation and political polarization in contemporary Sweden

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS · 2026-07-30

Why it matters · The article connects residential sorting across education, work, family, and housing trajectories to the geography of political polarization, with homeownership emerging as a major divider.

Open article →

ICE arrests, 2015-2026: Variation in targeting, method, and geography

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-07-27

Why it matters · Complete administrative data on 1.6 million ICE arrests reveal how enforcement targets and tactics shifted across administrations and diverged from public-safety narratives.

Open article →

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Late Additions

- Nature Human Behaviour

COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
284	127	156
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES	**CURATED DIGEST BELOW**	**NOTE**
1	18 new, 23 catch-up, 1 late addition	These counts reflect the complete collected set before manual relevance filtering, while the attached PDF reflects the curated digest.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

Political Analysis

The Power of Prognosis: Improving Covariate Balance Tests with Outcome Information

2026-07-31 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10050

Clara Bicalho; Adam Bouyamourn; Thad Dunning

Princeton University; Stanford University; University of California Berkeley

Abstract. Abstract Scholars frequently use covariate balance tests to test the validity of natural experiments and related designs. Unfortunately, when measured covariates are unrelated to potential outcomes, balance is uninformative about key identification conditions. We show that balance tests can then lead to erroneous conclusions. To build stronger tests, researchers should identify covariates that are jointly predictive of potential outcomes; formally measure and report covariate prognosis; and prioritize the most individually informative variables in tests. Building on prior research on "prognostic scores," we develop bootstrap balance tests that upweight covariates associated with the outcome. We adapt this approach for regression-discontinuity designs and use simulations to compare weighting methods based on linear regression and more flexible methods, including machine learning. The results show how prognosis weighting can avoid both false negatives and false positives. To illustrate key points, we study empirical examples from a sample of published studies, including an important debate over close elections.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

Social dynamics of AI adoption in parents' educational decisions

2026-07-31 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2533193123

Leonardo Bursztyn; Alex Imas; Rafael Jimenez-Duran; Aaron Leonard; Christopher Roth

Booth School of Business, University of Chicago; Department of Economics, Bocconi University; Department of Economics, University of Chicago; Department of Economics, University of Cologne

Abstract. When adopting a performance-enhancing technology offers short-run relative advantages, competitive pressure can drive diffusion even if most adopters would prefer a collective ban. We study this dynamic in the context of unrestricted AI tools for teenagers' education. In preregistered, incentive-compatible experiments with approximately 2,000 parents in the United States, Canada, and the United Kingdom, we elicit willingness to pay for a three-month premium subscription to a leading general-purpose AI platform. Demand increases steeply with the share of other teenagers using AI: Moving perceived peer take-up from 20% to 80% raises willingness to pay by more than 60%. We then test whether information about emerging evidence on potential downstream skill effects changes behavior. Risk information substantially shifts incentivized beliefs about longer-run impacts but has little effect on individual demand, yet it strongly increases support for school-level restrictions. Follow-up experiments show that peer-adoption information does not significantly shift perceived AI quality, the importance parents assign to core skills, or support for bans, pointing to social pressure rather than social learning as the primary channel. The results reveal a rat-race dynamic in which individual adoption responds to peers even as collective preferences shift toward restriction.

Read article →

A demographic theory of similarity-biased social learning

2026-07-30 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2606741123

Alejandro Perez Velilla; Paul E. Smaldino

Complexity Science Hub; Department of Cognitive and Information Sciences, University of California; Department of Human Behavior, Ecology and Culture, Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology; Santa Fe Institute

Abstract. We develop a demographic theory of similarity-biased social learning that formalizes our understanding of when and why individuals should preferentially copy others that look or act like them. We build an evolutionary model in which individuals can either learn on their own or copy others from a demonstrator pool that contains varying proportions of in-group and out-group members, and where group tags can be more or less informative about local knowledge. We find that where social learning becomes common, selection favors copying biases that track the direction of informational advantage-toward the group that tends to be better adapted to local conditions, including an antisimilarity bias when tags are negatively associated with local correctness (as may be the case for some immigrant communities). We also find conditions in which a similarity bias can stabilize social learning when such learners are already common, but not when they are rare, with implications for the role of group identities in cultural evolution. We discuss implications for understanding parochialism as risk aversion, majority-minority dynamics, the sociology of immigration, and the lasting impacts of colonialism.

Read article →

Parenthood decisions in uncertain times: Experimental evidence from four countries

2026-07-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2601690123

Arnstein Aassve; Letizia Mencarini; Chen Peng; Samuel Plach; Alonso Roman Amarales; Maria Letizia Tanturri

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Abstract. Fertility rates are declining across much of the globe, yet the forces driving this decline have become increasingly complex, and classic theories have become less adequate to explain recent trends. While economic and gender-related explanations have long dominated fertility research, emerging global uncertainties, such as climate change, democratic backsliding, economic crises, and regional conflicts, may also shape how individuals evaluate childbearing. In addition to the more classical factors, this cross-national study examines how macrolevel uncertainties influence perceptions of fertility intentions in Italy, Argentina, the United States, and Germany. These countries offer distinct fertility trajectories and face unique combinations of sociopolitical and environmental challenges. Using a conjoint experiment, we examine how individuals evaluate, across hypothetical scenarios, their intention of having a child under varying household, policy, and macrolevel conditions. Across all four countries, material security remains central: household income is the strongest predictor of fertility intentions, with homeownership and childcare playing smaller roles. At the same time, perceptions of macrolevel stability, including expectations about climate conditions, economic prospects, democratic functioning, and peace, exert substantial and meaningful effects, comparable to homeownership and childcare provision but more pronounced than those associated with gender-role arrangements. Cross-country differences show that macroeconomic stability and climate change are most consequential in Argentina, while in the United States respondents are less responsive to geopolitical conflict. These findings show that individuals evaluate childbearing not only through their immediate circumstances, but also through expectations about broader societal futures, highlighting the importance of incorporating macrolevel uncertainty when explaining contemporary fertility decline.

Read article →

Psychological inoculation against climate doom

2026-07-28 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2609074123

Rachel O'Boyle; Tyler Shores; Sander van der Linden

Department of Psychology, University of Cambridge; University of Cambridge ThinkLab, Jesus College, University of Cambridge, Jesus Lane

Abstract. Individuals encounter "climate doom," extreme portrayals of climate change, on social media. While climate doom may be intended to motivate action, it may also be perceived as manipulative or elicit hopelessness. Yet, no research has examined whether psychological inoculation helps to improve recognition of climate doom or influences engagement with it on social media. In this preregistered study (n = 521), we tested whether inoculation improves discernment of climate doom and influences engagement with it by collecting behavioral data using a social media simulator. We find that inoculation substantially improves discernment of climate doom and that this is due to increased perceived manipulation of doom messaging specifically (d = 0.68). There was no interaction between the inoculation condition and political leaning and while higher perceived manipulation of doom content predicted lower behavioral intentions, inoculation did not moderate this relationship. Inoculation increased engagement, particularly disliking and flagging of doom content, and decreased sharing. Overall, our results should lead climate communicators to reconsider doom messaging as a mobilization strategy and demonstrate that inoculation is an effective tool for increasing recognition of, and critical engagement with, climate doom across the political spectrum.

Read article →

ICE arrests, 2015-2026: Variation in targeting, method, and geography

2026-07-27 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2618096123

Chloe N. East; Caitlin Patler; Elizabeth Cox

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Abstract. We analyze and decompose administrative data on all 1.6 million US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) arrests from October 2015 to March 2026. Our results reveal that the reality of immigration enforcement diverges sharply from the public narrative that ICE arrests are necessary to protect public safety by removing people who commit crimes: Although arrests spiked at the outset of both Trump presidencies, the share of arrested individuals with criminal convictions fell significantly, with especially marked declines in 2025. A shift in ICE tactics partly explains this pattern, but even conditional on tactic, the share with a criminal conviction declined as arrests rose. Moreover, we find substantial geographic heterogeneity in ICE methods, despite nearly universal declines in the criminal conviction rate. Our findings provide important evidence for policymakers, the general public, and researchers studying this period of immigration policy.

Read article →

Science Advances

Most people who agree with you won't protest: Predictors of marches and demonstrations from six decades of research

2026-07-31 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEA8409

Shelley Boulianne; Jennifer Earl

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Abstract. Protest and activism are endemic and potent features of many nations' political life and critical potential counters to democratic backsliding and authoritarianism. In this review article, we meta-analytically examine six decades of research findings on what explains participation, focusing particularly on two well-studied protest forms: marches and demonstrations. Focusing on these iconic and common forms of protest participation ensures accurate research comparison, allowing us to identify sets of variables that are consistently important, others that are not consistently important, and still others that need additional research. Our focus on survey-based studies also allows us to compare research that includes both participants

and nonparticipants, which is critical for methodologically sound comparisons. Our analysis of 181 survey-based studies (with more than 1800 different estimates) shows that survey research strongly supports the relevance of political interest, political ideology, membership in organizations, and digital/social media use in explaining participation, as well as demographic variables such as education, age, and living in an urban center. Our review also offers important suggestions for future survey research and micromobilization research more broadly.

Read article →

Untrustworthy sources on Facebook and Instagram in 2020: Concentrated exposure but no attitudinal effects

2026-07-31 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.ADZ6502

Olivier Bergeron-Boutin; Brendan Nyhan; Jaime Settle; Emily Thorson; Magdalena Wojcieszak; Taylor Brown; Adriana Crespo-Tenorio; Carlos Velasco Rivera; Hunt Allcott; Pablo Barbera; Drew Dimmery; Deen Freelon; Matthew Gentzkow; Sandra Gonzalez-Bailon; Andrew M. Guess; Edward Kennedy; Young Mie Kim; David Lazer; Neil Malhotra; Devra Moehler; Jennifer Pan; Daniel Robert Thomas; Rebekah Tromble; Arjun Wilkins; Beixian Xiong; Chad Kiewiet de Jonge; Annie Franco; Winter Mason; Natalie Jomini Stroud; Joshua A. Tucker

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Abstract. Despite concern about exposure to content from untrustworthy sources on social media, little is known about the frequency or effects of exposure to their content. We examine 2020 data from all active US adults on Facebook and Instagram to measure exposure to content from Pages, groups, and web domains on Facebook and public accounts on Instagram that repeatedly publish misinformation. We find that average users saw relatively little content in their feeds from these untrustworthy sources; exposure was highly concentrated. A multimonth field experiment during the 2020 election among consenting users reduced feed-based exposure to content from untrustworthy sources by approximately 70% on both platforms but had no measurable effects on numerous preregistered outcomes, even among participants with high pretreatment exposure. Our results demonstrate that a feasible platform intervention can successfully reduce exposure to content from untrustworthy sources but suggest that these changes are unlikely to have immediate effects on attitudes and beliefs.

Read article →

American Political Science Review

A Democratic Theory of Labor Unions

2026-07-30 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101804

STEVEN KLEIN

King's College London

Abstract. Recently, political theorists have been increasingly concerned with the implications of democratic values for work. This article contributes to these debates by examining the main vehicle through which workers, historically, have sought democracy at work: the labor union. The article defends a vision of economic democracy that arises from the practice of labor

unions. It then emphasizes the distinctive features of labor unions that make them potential vehicles for democracy in other domains. Labor unions are particularly important means of advancing democratic values for three reasons: (1) their ability to appeal to the short- and mid-term self-interest of their members; (2) their anchor in the material reproduction of society; and (3) that they rely on attitudes of cooperation and solidarity among their members. Yet these three features also point to potential limitations of labor unions as laboratories of democracy.

Read article →

Redistricting Reforms Reduce Gerrymandering by Constraining Partisan Actors

2026-07-30 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101610

CORY McCARTAN; CHRISTOPHER T. KENNY; TYLER SIMKO; EMMA EBOWE; MICHAEL Y. ZHAO; KOSUKE IMAI

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Abstract. Political actors often manipulate redistricting plans to gain electoral advantages, a process known as gerrymandering. Several states have implemented institutional reforms to address this problem, such as establishing map-drawing commissions. Estimating the impact of these reforms is challenging because each state structures its processes and rules differently. We model redistricting as a sequential game whose equilibrium solution summarizes multistep institutional interactions as a univariate score. We argue that this score measures the leeway political actors have over the partisan lean of the final plan. Our differences-in-differences analysis demonstrates that reforms reduce partisan bias and increase competitiveness by constraining partisan actors. We perform a counterfactual policy analysis to estimate the effects of enacting recent reforms nationwide. Though commissions are likely to reduce bias, reforms that restrict partisan actors in multiple ways, such as removing veto points (Michigan), are more effective than commissions where parties retain some control (Ohio).

Read article →

Contested Governance and Civilian Prosocial Behavior: Evidence from Lab-in-the-Field Experiments in India

2026-07-29 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101701

BRANDON BOLTE; VINEETA YADAV; BUMBA MUKHERJEE

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Abstract. How does contested governance by states and competing armed actors affect the behavior of the governed? During civil conflicts, rebel organizations frequently provide public goods, judicial arbitration, and security, but these forms of governance often operate alongside local state institutions. Beyond avoiding violence, therefore, noncombatants must navigate the daily uncertainty of local governance by states and armed groups vying for territorial control. This, we argue, shapes their quotidian interactions with one another. Using a series of lab-in-the-field experiments and surveys from Naxal-affected Bihar, India, we find that individuals living under such contested governance exhibit greater interpersonal trust and trustworthiness and less opportunistic behavior. We propose two mechanisms to explain these patterns-fearing intra-community retaliation or substituting for the state with interpersonal reliance. Most evidence is only consistent with the latter. By connecting governance, rebellion, and social capital, this work makes important contributions toward understanding the micro-politics of local order during longstanding armed conflicts.

Read article →

Is Blood Thicker Than Water(-and-Earth)? Partisanship Geography in Imperial China and the Limits of Quantitative History

2026-07-29 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055425100853

YAO LIN

University of Detroit Mercy

Abstract. Using Wang Anshi's Reform as a case study, Yuhua Wang's "Blood is Thicker Than Water" (American Political Science Review , 2022) argues that geographically dispersed kinship networks incentivize political elites to support the building of a strong state, whereas geographically concentrated kinship networks undermine state building. In this article, I improve the sample with the help of additional historical records and show that the reported correlation fails to replicate when either the control issue or the outlier issue is considered. I then propose two alternative hypotheses on the role of kinship network dispersal in Wang Anshi's Reform, based on two common explanations of its partisanship geography in Chinese historical scholarship, that is, status competition and policy adaptiveness. After examining those hypotheses respectively, I reflect on the limits of quantitative history that this case illustrates.

Read article →

Still Instrumentally Inclusive

2026-07-28 · DOI 10.1017/S0003055426101828

STUART J. TURNBULL-DUGARTE; ALBERTO LOPEZ ORTEGA

University of Southampton; Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam

Abstract. Do individuals in Western democracies shift their views on LGBT+ inclusion when exposed to opposition from Muslim out-groups? And is this "homonationalist" responsiveness stronger among anti-immigration individuals? Our article "Instrumentally inclusive [...]" addressed these questions using representative data from Britain (Study 1) and crowd-sourced data from Spain (Study 2). We revisit Study 2 in response to concerns about post-stratification weighting a convenience sample and erroneously inconsistent use of robust standard errors. Varying population reference parameters, weight caps, variance estimators, subgroup definitions, and covariate adjustments, we find strong support for the original findings. Neither reasonable alternative weighting schemes nor corrected variance estimators substantively change the results. In fact, the originally published point estimates are equal to or smaller than the median across alternative specifications. Consistent with the Article, we find that treatment increases support for LGBT+ inclusion in Spain, without consistent identifiable variation by immigration attitudes.

Read article →

Nature Communications

Life course trajectory segregation and political polarization in contemporary Sweden

2026-07-30 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-75072-Y

Bo Malmberg; Juta Kawalerowicz; Eva K. Andersson

Abstract. Abstract Understanding how and why places differ geographically has long been central to human geography-a question sharpened by the growing geographical polarization of political views. Spatial polarization can result from an uneven geographical distribution of life-course trajectories, trajectories that emerge from individuals' successive positions across interconnected, possibly spatially differentiated social fields such as education, employment, family, and housing. Here we show that the uneven geographical distribution of such trajectories produces landscapes where contrasting life experiences, opportunities, and aspirations become inscribed in geographical space. A key finding is that segregation intensifies over the life-course, with young adults substantially less segregated than older adults, particularly after homeownership transitions. Moreover, studies relying on single indicators such as income and education may underestimate residential segregation strength. Homeownership is a major segregation driver, creating highly separated residential areas in later life phases. The spatial concentration of trajectory types also corresponds with geographical patterns in political polarization.

Read article →

Nature

Relatively few Black people benefited in the 1930s and 1940s from mortgages backed by the US government

2026-07-29 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02246-5

Abstract. Newly digitized mortgage records from 38 US states reveal the profound racial inequality of two mortgage programmes during the 1930s and 1940s. These loans, supported by the Federal Housing Administration and the Veterans Administration, were mainly responsible for the emergence of a US society that idealized home ownership. However, Black households were systematically excluded from receiving such loans. By contrast, immigrants received mortgages proportional to their number. Immigrants, who were mainly from Europe at the time, were proportionally represented among loan recipients in the United States.

Read article →

Political Communication

Happiness in Political Communication by Men and Women Members of the US Congress

2026-07-29 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2705676

Constantine Boussalis; Travis G. Coan; Mirya R. Holman

Trinity College Dublin; University of Exeter; University of Houston

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

Read article →

Networked Counterpublics and Contentious Publicity: A Cross-Platform Analysis of QAnon on Parler and Twitter

2026-07-27 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2708132

Sang Jung Kim; Jordan Foley; Yunkang Yang; Keyeun Lee

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Abstract. Extremist online movements often leverage social media affordances to shape in-group identity and influence broader publics through agenda-setting practices. This study uses QAnon as a case of a networked counterpublic to examine how these processes unfolded between 2018 and 2021. Drawing on affordance theory, we analyze how QAnon discourse activated the affordances of visibility, association, and persistence on Parler and Twitter - two platforms similar in technical features but distinct in their cultures of use. We identify differentiated affordance-activation practices that support different counterpublic functions: for example, hashtag stacking on Parler can be interpreted as contributing to identity-oriented meaning-making, whereas calls to "do your own research" on Twitter may function as epistemic invitations aimed at drawing mainstream users into conspiratorial interpretation. We further show that QAnon's contentious publicness - the contestation of pro- and anti-QAnon claims - shifted dynamically across the movement's developmental stages, and that identical informational resources (shared URLs) generated divergent discursive trajectories across platforms. By tracing these temporal and cross-platform dynamics, we illuminate how extremist counterpublics navigate visibility, identity work, and public contestation, offering insights for the study of political communication in an era of networked extremism.

Read article →

Communication Research

The Bio-Functional Audience: Shared Physiological Alignment to Narrative Media

2026-07-28 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261472026

Ralf Schmalzle; Hee Jung Cho; Monique Mitchell Turner

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Abstract. Communication research into audience responses has traditionally emphasized how individual or group differences create variance in interpretation while overlooking a more fundamental phenomenon: the capacity of the same message to induce similar responses across receivers. We introduce a bio-functional definition of the audience, a temporal collective bound together by the moment-to-moment alignment of its members' physiological responses. In a large-scale experiment (N = 198) monitoring eye-tracking, heart rate, and electrodermal activity during a film, we mapped a processing hierarchy in which audience response alignment was strongest for gaze but also extended into downstream autonomic responses. Furthermore, a temporal manipulation of the narrative sequence abolished aligned responses, confirming that the induced audience state is driven by the message content. We conclude that messages function as alignment devices that reduce individual noise and bring distinct individuals into a shared processing state, thus providing a grounded, signal-based definition of the audience as a bio-functional entity.

Read article →

Previous Week Catch-Up

Communication Methods and Measures

Polarization as a linguistic feature: a systematic review of computational operationalizations of polarization

2026-07-26 · DOI 10.1080/19312458.2026.2704557

Helena Rauxloh

GESIS Leibniz Institute for the Social Sciences

Abstract. This systematic review maps associations between linguistic features and computational methods used to operationalize polarization in text data. Using the PRISMA method, the review searched the bibliographic databases Web of Science, Dimensions, and Elicit as of 03.11.2025, yielding 63 publications after screening. Data extraction captured target concepts, linguistic indicators, computational methods, and publication characteristics. The synthesis uses descriptive and relational approaches to examine frequencies, temporal trends, and associations between concepts, indicators, and methods. Findings show distinct patterns in affect-laden indicators, especially sentiment and emotion, which are often combined with pronoun-based group-reference measures. Rule-based approaches are still widely used for grammatical features, while recent work increasingly uses pretrained or large language models for context-dependent indicators. Future research should validate key indicator combinations and relate them to established polarization measures beyond text-as-data research.

Read article →

Communication Research

Music Was My First Love: Biographic Resonance Makes Everyday Music Listening Meaningful

2026-07-26 · DOI 10.1177/00936502261468400

Felix Dietrich; Alicia Ernst; Benedikt Rohr; Michael Scharkow; Leonard Reinecke

Johannes Gutenberg University Mainz, Germany

Abstract. Despite much research on eudaimonic media experiences, little is known about how and why certain content is perceived as meaningful by certain users in certain situations. We therefore examine biographic resonance - connections between entertainment content and users' biographic memories - during everyday music listening on Spotify and propose that memory recall, as well as its emotional valence, relate to meaningfulness via distinct patterns of intrinsic need satisfaction. Results from a preregistered, intensive-longitudinal study (144 persons; 6,920 situations) reveal that biographic resonance relates to both high- and low-effort modes of eudaimonic entertainment. Moreover, by linking users' self-reports with their tracked digital music use (2,786 sessions; 107,147 songs), we find that the occurrence and quality of biographic resonance vary across situations and are shaped by both content and contextual factors within algorithmically curated environments. Our results highlight how resonances between media users' selves and entertainment content foster situational meaningfulness in everyday life.

Read article →

Human Communication Research

Technology-mediated communication among migrant families separated by borders: understanding the tensions of relational maintenance

2026-07-26 · DOI 10.1093/HCR/HQAG003

Hyojin Lee; Jennifer A Kam; Nancy Molina-Rogers; Ricardo Delgado Solis; Amy Gonzales

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Abstract. Abstract This study examined how highly under-resourced Latina/o/x/e families used technologically mediated communication to maintain their relationship when experiencing migration-based family separation. Drawing on relational maintenance literature, semi-structured interviews were conducted with 27 family triads, each including a father, mother, and child (children between 9 and 17 years old). The findings extend past research on relational maintenance by elucidating how structural barriers and culture contribute to tensions in relational maintenance and by providing within-family and between-family triangulated perspectives. Across families, three recurring relational maintenance strategies were consistently tensional: (a) sustaining routine contact, (b) prioritizing real-time interaction, and (c) practicing selective disclosure. The findings from within-family and between-family analyses showed how relational maintenance, which was primarily mediated by technology, became highly tensional under structural barriers and cultural norms and had unevenly distributed costs for family members.

Read article →

Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication

Chatting with confidants or corporations? Privacy management with AI companions

2026-07-24 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG014

Hsuen-Chi Chiu; Jeremy Foote

Brian Lamb School of Communication, Purdue University , West Lafayette, IN,

Abstract. Abstract AI companion chatbots feel like intimate confidants but exist as part of corporate data systems. Drawing on Communication Privacy Management (CPM) theory and Masur's dimensional privacy framework, we interviewed users of platforms like Replika and Character.AI (N = 15) to understand their privacy decisions in AI companion interactions. We find that anthropomorphic design lowers disclosure thresholds, encouraging increasingly intimate self-disclosure. As relationships develop, some users engage in simulated co-ownership, treating shared information as relationally held despite recognizing corporate control. Because post-disclosure correction feels futile, privacy management becomes anticipatory and front-loaded-users rely on distancing strategies such as using fake names rather than post-hoc deletion. For some users,

privacy turbulence centers less on fears of exposure and more on fears of losing conversational memory-a relational reset feels more threatening than a data breach. These findings extend CPM theory by showing that in human-AI companionship contexts, relational and institutional privacy concerns become inextricably entangled.

Read article →

Nature Machine Intelligence

Capable language models can outgrow the benefits of collaboration

2026-07-24 · DOI 10.1038/S42256-026-01268-Y

Yubin Kim; Ken Gu; Chanwoo Park; Chunjong Park; Samuel Schmidgall; A. Ali Heydari; Yao Yan; Zhihan Zhang; Yuchen Zhuang; Yun Liu; Mark Malhotra; Paul Pu Liang; Hae Won Park; Yuzhe Yang; Xuhai Xu; Yilun Du; Shwetak Patel; Tim Althoff; Daniel McDuff; Xin Liu

Abstract. Agents, language model-based systems that can reason, plan and act with tools to accomplish tasks, are widely deployed, yet it remains unclear when multi-agent coordination outperforms a strong single agent. Here we conduct a controlled experiment that holds task prompts, tools and compute budgets constant while varying only coordination structure and model capability. Across 260 configurations spanning six benchmarks, five architectures and three LLM families, we derive a predictive model using empirical coordination metrics. Across benchmarks, single-agent baseline performance emerges as the most robust predictor of whether coordination improves or decreases performance. In particular, we identify an empirical capability-saturation threshold beyond which additional agents are unlikely to improve performance. This threshold correctly predicts the effect of multi-agent coordination on performance in 94% of validation configurations on SWE-bench Verified and Terminal-Bench. We therefore interpret this threshold as a practical selection rule rather than a universal scaling principle. A second effect, baseline-scaled error amplification, survives cluster-robust inference (Probust = 0.030) and supports the failure-mode taxonomy. The fitted model achieves cross-validated R2 = 0.373 (0.413 with a task-grounded capability metric) and selects the best architecture in 87% of held-out configurations. These results provide a quantitative framework for within-domain architecture selection and for estimating when multi-agent coordination is likely to improve performance or add overhead. A controlled study of large language model agents across 260 configurations shows when multi-agent collaboration helps or hurts performance, and introduces a predictive model that selects the best architecture in 87% of held-out within-domain configurations.

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Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

The social-class gap in negotiation: Lower-class individuals negotiate less and face more backlash

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Abstract. Economic inequality has widened considerably in the United States and globally, raising pressing questions about the mechanisms that reproduce social stratification. One prominent manifestation of this inequality is the "class ceiling" in organizations: individuals from lower social classes earn less and advance more slowly than their higher-class counterparts, even with comparable credentials. We identify a crucial behavioral pathway contributing to this class ceiling: a social-class gap in the propensity to negotiate. We propose that lower-class individuals are less likely to initiate negotiations than their higher-class counterparts, a pattern that can compound economic disadvantage over time. Across four studies (total N = 10,211)-including a nationally representative sample of employees (Study 1), a sample of business school students (Study 2), a field study of an online labor market (Study 3), and a survey study of workplace negotiations and career outcomes (Study 4)-we find consistent evidence for this gap. This gap is partially explained by lower-class individuals' reduced sense of power

and heightened concerns about social backlash. Additionally, Study 5 (N = 1,133) finds that such concerns may be justified: an experiment with human resources (HR) professionals shows that identical negotiation requests elicit stronger social backlash when initiated by lower-class (vs. higher-class) individuals. Together, these findings reveal a pernicious double bind for lower-class individuals: remaining silent perpetuates economic disadvantage, yet initiating negotiation exposes them to greater social penalties. Addressing this double bind is critical for ensuring that negotiation serves as a vehicle for upward mobility rather than a gatekeeper of privilege.

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Continuity and change in US legal tradition: Evidence from judicial citation communities

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509763123

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Abstract. Legal doctrine is often described as evolving case by case while preserving coherent legal traditions. We introduce a method for identifying and tracing such traditions by applying the Louvain community-detection algorithm to the complete U.S. federal judicial citation graph (1790-2024; 760,000 opinions linked by 8.3 million citations). The resulting citation communities are unsupervised, blind to court labels and topical taxonomies, yet they form meaningful empirical groupings: In validation exercises, they recover known institutional structure and capture coherent substantive and procedural approaches to law. Using these communities as empirical units, we study how legal traditions evolve and respond to legislative change. We show that the introduction of pivotal federal statutes shifts citation patterns toward newer precedent, indicating that legislation can disrupt established traditions and redirect the development of case law.

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Dietary DNA in municipal wastewater reveals signatures of wealth, immigration, and coastal proximity

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Abstract. Public health nutrition lacks scalable, objective tools for real-time dietary surveillance. We developed FoodSeq-FLOW (Food Landscape Observation in Wastewater), a genomic platform that sequences chloroplast trnL and mitochondrial 12SV5 DNA in municipal wastewater. Across 183 samples from 21 North Carolina wastewater treatment plants serving 2.1 million people, we detected 184 plant and 116 animal food taxa at a cost of

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Gender pay gaps in the social sciences

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Abstract. We provide a longitudinal, multifield analysis of the gender pay gap in academia that directly links individual-level salaries to measures of scholarly productivity. Using administrative data from the ten campuses that comprise the University

of California system, we combine detailed pay records with bibliometric data on publications and citations for faculty in five major social science fields. We find a raw gender pay gap of 23%, which decreases to 4.3% after controlling for field, campus, and cohort. Including controls for job title and scholarly productivity has little effect on the estimated gap, although they substantially increase explanatory power. A decomposition shows that 17% of the gap is unexplained, persisting across junior and senior faculty. We also find a large, persistent gender gap in publications, but no citation gap once output and career length are considered. Field-level analysis reveals that pay gaps are not universal: They persist in Business, Sociology, and Anthropology, but are absent in Economics, Political Science, and smaller social science fields. Our results suggest that pay transparency is insufficient to eliminate salary disparities and that more equal representation within the field is not a prerequisite for pay equity. Our study isolates the residual gap that remains unexplained by productivity or seniority, challenging the view that these factors fully account for gender pay differences. Taken together, our findings highlight the role of field-specific norms and institutional structures, offering directions to promote equitable compensation in academia.

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Legal infrastructure for transformative AI governance

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509742123

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Abstract. Most of our AI governance efforts focus on substance: What rules do we want in place? What limits or checks do we want to impose on AI development and deployment? But a key role for law is not only to establish substantive rules but also to establish legal and regulatory infrastructure to generate and implement rules. The transformative nature of AI calls especially for attention to building legal and regulatory frameworks. In this Perspective, I review three examples: the creation of registration regimes for frontier models; the creation of registration and identification regimes for autonomous agents; and the design of regulatory markets to facilitate a role for private companies to innovate and deliver AI regulatory services.

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Measuring disparate impact in human and machine decisions

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509765122

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Abstract. Empirical analyses have grown increasingly important in discrimination litigation with the greater availability of detailed data on individuals and decisions. A popular analytic strategy is to estimate disparities after adjusting for observed covariates, typically with a regression model, in hopes of ferreting out discriminatory intent. This approach, however, is ill-suited to auditing algorithms that are now commonly used to aid decisions, which typically do not include race or other legally protected factors as inputs. Motivated by legal understandings of disparate impact, we introduce an approach that aims to measure "unjustified" disparities in both human and machine decisions. Our method, which we call risk-adjusted regression, proceeds in three steps. In the first step, we combine all available information in a machine learning model to estimate the value, or inversely, the risk, of taking a certain action, such as approving a loan application or hiring a job candidate. Second, we measure disparities in decisions after adjusting for these risk estimates alone. Finally, in the third step, we assess the sensitivity of results to potential mismeasurement of risk. We demonstrate this approach on a detailed dataset of 2.2 million police stops of pedestrians in New York City, and show that traditional statistical tests of discrimination can substantially understate the magnitude of (risk-adjusted) racial disparities.

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Public responses to atrocities depend on partisanship and context, not legal labels

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Abstract. Legal labels such as genocide and crimes against humanity carry substantial legal and diplomatic weight in elite and institutional arenas, where classification shapes treaty obligations, ICC jurisdiction, and the perceived stakes of inaction. A common assumption in advocacy and policy discourse is that these labels also shape mass public judgment. Direct evidence is limited and ambiguous. We test this assumption in a preregistered, nationally representative survey experiment (N = 2 , 000) comparing four legally salient atrocity terms-genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, and ethnic cleansing-against a nonlegal control across five real-world conflict contexts, measuring support for punitive and humanitarian policies as well as moral attributions of responsibility. Across outcomes, estimated label effects are small and rarely distinguishable from zero. Critically, even within a given partisan and country context, swapping legal labels produces smaller shifts than the baseline gaps across partisan and geopolitical contexts-indicating that where you stand and who you are matter far more than what word is used. Any departures from zero are narrow and do not accumulate into a consistent pattern across outcomes or conflicts. These results suggest that the political significance of atrocity labeling lies primarily in elite and institutional arenas; for mass publics, legal terminology is a weak lever compared to country context and partisan commitments.

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Race-conscious admissions algorithms and the law

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509764123

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Abstract. In recent years, colleges and universities have begun to use machine learning (ML) systems to inform admissions decisions. Meanwhile, in the 2023 case Students for Fair Admissions, Inc. v. President and Fellows of Harvard College , the Supreme Court held that colleges and universities may not make admissions decisions "on the basis of race." These parallel developments-the rise of ML in admissions and the fall of race-based affirmative action-will force educational institutions, and ultimately courts, to confront the difficult question of what it means for ML systems to differentiate "on the basis of race." We begin by mapping the Students for Fair Admissions decision onto different uses of race in predictive AI. We distinguish between "first-order" and "second-order" race consciousness at both the training and predictive phases of machine learning, and we argue that each category of race consciousness raises distinct legal and normative issues. We go on to show that the Students for Fair Admissions decision potentially permits-and even endorses-certain forms of race consciousness. Our analysis is grounded in the observation that the process of developing ML-based systems enables policymakers to calibrate decision making algorithms much more precisely and explicitly in response to specific criticisms of race-conscious affirmative action.

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Statutory construction and interpretation for AI

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Abstract. AI systems are increasingly governed by natural language rules, yet a key challenge arising from reliance on language remains underexplored: interpretive ambiguity. As in legal systems, ambiguity arises both from how these rules are written and how they are applied. But while legal systems use institutional safeguards to manage such ambiguity, such as

transparent appellate review policing interpretive constraints, rule-based AI alignment pipelines lack comparable protections. Different interpretations of the same rule can lead to inconsistent model behavior. Drawing on U.S. legal theory, we identify key gaps in current rule-based alignment pipelines by examining how legal systems constrain ambiguity at both the rule creation and rule application steps. We then propose a computational framework that formalizes interpretive ambiguity as constrained entropy minimization and introduces two law-inspired mechanisms: 1) a rule refinement pipeline that minimizes interpretive disagreement by revising ambiguous rules (analogous to agency rulemaking or iterative legislative action), and 2) prompt-based interpretive constraints that reduce disagreement during rule application (analogous to legal canons that guide judicial discretion). We evaluate our framework on a 5,000-scenario subset of the WildChat dataset and show that both interventions significantly improve judgment consistency across a panel of reasonable interpreters. Our approach offers a step toward systematically managing interpretive ambiguity, an essential step for building more robust, law-following AI systems.

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The backfiring effect of weak AI safety regulation

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509768123

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Abstract. Recent policy proposals aim to improve the safety of general-purpose AI, but there is little understanding of the efficacy of different regulatory approaches. We present a strategic model that explores interactions between safety regulation, general-purpose AI technology creators, and domain specialists-those who adapt the technology for specific applications. Our analysis examines how regulatory measures targeting different parts of the AI development chain affect the outcome of this game. Our model assumes AI technology is characterized by two key attributes: safety and performance. The regulator first sets a minimum safety requirement that applies to one or both players. The general-purpose creator then invests in the technology, establishing its initial safety and performance levels. Next, domain specialists refine the AI for their use cases, updating the safety and performance levels and taking the product to market. Resulting revenue is shared between the specialist and generalist. Our analysis reveals two insights: first, weak safety regulation imposed predominantly on domain specialists can backfire. While it might seem logical to regulate AI use cases, our analysis shows that weak regulations targeting domain specialists alone can reduce safety in a large class of parameterizations. Second, in contrast to the previous finding, we observe that stronger, well-placed regulation can mutually benefit all players. When regulators impose appropriate safety standards on both general-purpose AI creators and domain specialists, the regulation can function as a commitment device, leading to safety and performance gains, surpassing what is achievable under no regulation or regulating only one player.

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There is no free benchmark: An institutional view of legal AI benchmarking

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2509757122

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Abstract. Despite substantial excitement around the use of AI in law, little information exists on the performance and associated risks of the domain's widely marketed tools. Recent work, for instance, has demonstrated the significant potential for "hallucinations"-wherein models make up facts, law, and precedent-leading Chief Justice Roberts to spotlight this risk in

his annual report on the judiciary. We argue that there is a need for public AI benchmarking in law. First, relative to other AI application domains, the legal AI ecosystem lacks legibility-there is little information about the design and performance of many commercial legal AI systems. Legal AI has not benefited from the types of benchmarking that have catalyzed, measured, and informed AI innovation and responsible use in other domains. Second, we articulate the challenges of the institutional design of benchmarking. We illustrate how benchmarks can be captured, watered down, and abused. Careful institutional design around the why, who, what, and how of benchmarking will be critical to navigate difficult tradeoffs of transparency, objectivity, expertise, and resources. Third, addressing legal AI's illegibility requires matching institutional models to available resources and constraints. Rather than advocating for a single "best" approach to benchmarking, we show how benchmarking strategies depend on available resources.

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American Journal of Political Science

Correcting measurement error bias in conjoint survey experiments

2026-07-23 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70076

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Abstract. Abstract Conjoint survey designs are spreading across the social sciences due to their unusual capacity to estimate many causal effects from a single randomized experiment. Unfortunately, by their ability to mirror complicated realworld choices, these designs often generate substantial measurement error and thus bias. We replicate both the data collection and analysis from eight prominent conjoint studies, all of which closely reproduce published results, and reveal high levels of measurement error in all. We then discover a common empirical pattern in how measurement error appears in conjoint studies and, with it, introduce an easytouse statistical method to correct the bias. Along the way, we provide a much simpler and simultaneously more powerful approach to designing, organizing, understanding, and analyzing conjoint data analyses.

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Nature Communications

Disproportionate exposure to extreme floods in historically redlined U.S. communities

2026-07-23 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-76024-2

Elizabeth Appel; S. Amin Enderami; Elaina J. Sutley; Admin Husic

Abstract. Abstract Extreme floods and historical public policies both leave lasting impacts. We analyzed flood exposure across the neighborhoods of 202 US cities historically assessed for lending risk by the Home Owners' Loan Corporation on a scale from 'best (A) to 'hazardous' (D). Using high-resolution flood modeling and dasymetric population mapping, we found that D-graded neighborhoods bear a disproportionate flood burden in roughly three-quarters of cities. This inequality follows a systematic gradient: A- and B-graded neighborhoods are underrepresented in the flooded population, C-graded neighborhoods are proportionately represented, and D-graded neighborhoods are overrepresented. A greater fraction of D-graded residents are exposed to the 100-yr flood (6.4%) than A-graded residents to the 1000-yr flood (5.9%) with the gap widening at higher-magnitude floods. Flood disparities are most pronounced in the Midwest and Mid-Atlantic regions, aligning with the historical concentration of industrial labor and redlined neighborhoods along waterways. However, we find that proximity to waterways alone does not explain the observed inequality: flood disparities persist even among neighborhoods far from major rivers and coasts, implicating infrastructure deficits as a compounding factor. Neighborhoods marked as

'hazardous' nearly a century ago remain disproportionately vulnerable today, underscoring the need for equitable urban planning.

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Structural inequality shapes the daily rhythm of stationarity and mobility

2026-07-23 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-75778-Z

Zihao Tian; Chao Zhang; Weiyu Li; Lixin Tian; Michael M. Danziger; Wenshan Liu; Qi R. Wang

Abstract. Human mobility exhibits rhythmic patterns that shape economic activity, social interactions, and access to essential services. Yet, while prior studies focus on spatial movement, the temporal structure of people's stationarity-the act of dwelling-remains underexplored. Here, we introduce the Stationarity Sinusoidal Stability (STASIS) model to quantify the daily pulse of physical presence. Using three parameters-range, phase angle, and baseline-we show that majority-Black census block groups (CBGs) have smaller daily stationarity ranges, later activity peaks, and lower average home-presence baselines than majority-White and majority-Hispanic CBGs. The Rhythm Stability Index further indicates greater variability in activity timing among CBGs with higher proportions of Black residents, and this variability is associated with CBG-level economic precarity. Using COVID-19 as a stress test, our findings show that temporal stability in daily mobility rhythms differs across CBGs with different racial and Hispanic-origin compositions. The authors model daily routines of rest and activity, revealing that majority-Black communities experience highly volatile schedules. This shows that temporal predictability is a fundamental yet overlooked dimension of social justice.

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Political Communication

Common Identities and Political Talk: Evaluating Cross-Cutting Political Discussions in Sports Communities on Reddit

2026-07-23 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2704899

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Abstract. Research suggests that online nonpolitical communities may facilitate better cross-cutting political discussions than explicitly political communities as users' shared nonpolitical identities can offset partisan bias, in line with the Common Ingroup Identity Model. This study tests this idea through a large-scale computational analysis comparing the quantity, tone, and substance of political discussions on the same topics in political and sports communities on Reddit. Overall, we find that sports communities facilitate more cross-cutting political discussions than political communities, with the exception of soccer communities. These discussions use similar proportions of credible sources but use significantly fewer sources that are not credible compared to discussions in political communities. On the flip side, we do not find evidence of a meaningful difference in toxicity levels of cross-cutting political discussions in sports and political communities. Further, we find that political discussions in sports communities use fewer sources overall. These results advance a nuanced understanding of the promise of nonpolitical spaces for deliberative democracy and the role of common identities in political discussions.

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Affective Publics in the YouTube Live Chat: Multimodal Emotional Contagion During the 2024 U.S. Presidential Debate

2026-07-22 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2704891

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Abstract. Televised debates between political candidates have become dynamic, interactive events on live-streaming platforms where audiences form affective publics through real-time interactions and emotional expressions in live chat. In this study, we focused on real-time emotional contagion on a right-wing YouTube channel during the live-streamed 2024 U.S. presidential debate between Donald Trump and Kamala Harris. Examining how multimodal emotional expressions from candidates influence audience responses in live chats (N = 53,095), this study introduces a novel, multi-dimensional approach combining computational techniques, including face emotion recognition, speech emotion analysis, text emotion classification, and time series analysis, to analyze multimodal emotional cues across audio, video, and chat data. Results revealed that Harris' vocal fear Granger-caused an increase in joy in the live chat, and that emotional contagion patterns varied by user engagement level and political leaning: low-engagement users were primarily influenced by the candidates, whereas higher-engagement users were more influenced by peer emotions. Pro-Trump audiences' joy was amplified by Harris's vocal sadness; among pro-Harris audiences, anger increased in response to Harris's vocal sadness and the moderators' facial sadness, while joy increased in response to Trump's facial sadness. Negative public emotions including sadness and anger also reinforced joy in the live chat. These findings offer new insights into the role of emotional contagion in mobilizing online affective publics during live-streamed political events.

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Studying Propaganda as a Social Process

2026-07-22 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2706643

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Abstract. In recent scholarship on propaganda, no aspect has attracted more attention than the digitally mediated propagation of disinformation. In this intervention, we argue that focusing narrowly on disinformation risks missing the forest for all the trees: Only by considering disinformation's embedding within broader propaganda strategies and processes, we can understand falsehoods' distinctive rhetorical functions alongside other forms of (normative, motivational, etc.) propaganda messaging, comprehend their persuasive appeal, and theorize their capacity to gain discursive power within contemporary high-choice information environments. Advancing an approach that foregrounds propaganda's inherent anti-democratic ambition over its manipulative means, we sketch a research agenda suitable to studying propaganda as a social process.

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Nature Human Behaviour

Insights from climate psychology for misinformation research

2026-07-20 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02530-4

Tobia Spampatti; Bojana Veckalov; Sandra J. Geiger; Sander van der Linden; Stephan Lewandowsky; Matthew J. Hornsey

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Late Additions

Nature Human Behaviour

Stochastic models indicate rapid smallpox spread and mass mortality of Indigenous Australians after colonial exposure

2026-07-09 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02504-6

Matthew C. Nitschke; Alan N. Williams; Shane D. Ingrey; Billy Griffiths; Nicholas Pitt; Lynette Russell; Sean Ulm; Kirsty Beller; Michael I. Bird; Syeda H. Fatima; Ian J. McNiven; Frederik Saltre; Alison Bashford; Christopher Wilson; Corey J. A. Bradshaw

Abstract. The impact of smallpox (variola) on Aboriginal communities in Australia beginning in 1789 was catastrophic and continues to cause intergenerational trauma. Historically biased perspectives and contemporary misinformation of the disease's introduction and spread impede modern-day truth-telling and efforts towards reconciliation and national healing. Understanding whether the disease entered and spread from pre-colonial Makassan (Indonesian) trade along the northern coast, or from the British First Fleet's arrival in southeastern Australia in 1788, is necessary to estimate the demographic impact. Here we developed stochastic, multipatch epidemiological models supported by systematic evaluation of historical observations to test hypotheses regarding possible disease entry points, spread rate and demographic impacts. Our models support the hypothesis that entry of the disease was in southeastern Australia. Even under ideal conditions and with higher-than-probable infection rates, simulations show that smallpox was unlikely to reach Sydney from a northern entry. We found no evidence that the 1789 epidemic was Australia-wide. Assuming 60% lethality based on global data, the loss of approximately 220,000 people would have occurred in these regions. While catastrophic to traditional Indigenous lifeways in the southeast, the disease also provided the catalyst for population decline and marginalization of Indigenous people in the face of expanding European populations. Our models indicate that it is unlikely that other parts of Australia were affected by the initial epidemic. We warn readers that the content of this study might be distressing.

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